
Who Talks About What? Gendered Political Agendas in French Legislative Manifestos (1973–1993)

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Machine Learning for Natural Language Processing Report

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Abstract

This study examines gender-based thematic differences in political manifestos among candidates to legislative elections in France from 1973 to 1993, using the Archelec corpus produced by Science Po. I implement Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), an unsupervised machine learning technique, to discover the most frequently covered topics and assess their distribution by gender. The results suggest that political communication is not gender neutral. While men largely prioritize "high politics" and structural concerns, focusing on socioeconomic and regional development issues, as well as on electoral and institutional frameworks ; female candidates exhibit greater thematic breadth , often incorporating stronger ideological and identity-based components. They are more likely to engage with ecology, gender, and labor identity topics and to occupy the poles of the ideological spectrum, addressing either "regalian" traditionalism or far-left class struggle. Altogether, these findings suggest a gendered structuring of political communication and policy agendas in a context marked by low female representation and the ideological polarization of the Cold War and immediate post-Cold War transition.

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1 Introduction

Political scientists have long theorized the role that gender stereotypes play in the communication strategies of election candidates. Empirical evidence suggests that these translate into diverging communication styles and topics covered by women and men in politics. The strong focus of the literature on the United States and its traditional reliance on manual text processing make recent machine learning developments and increased text-data availability particularly appealing to study these dynamics across a broader range of political contexts in a large scale fashion [5].

This study examines gender thematic differences in political manifestos among candidates to legislative elections in France from 1973 to 1993, using the Archelec corpus produced by Science Po. I employ Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), an unsupervised machine learning technique, to discover the most frequently covered topics and assess their distribution by gender. LDA is particularly suited for this task as it acknowledges that political manifestos rarely adhere to a single theme and provides a clear and interpretable probabilistic framework¹.

The results indicate that male and female candidates prioritize distinct themes within their election manifestos. While men tend to focus on broad institutional and socioeconomic and regional issues, women navigate a more diverse thematic landscape by engaging with topics such as ecology, gender, and labor identity. This larger diversity is driven by inter-document heterogeneity, meaning that different women address a wider variety of issues across the corpus rather than individual women covering more topics per manifesto than their male counterparts.

Three mechanisms could explain this differentiation: (i) a higher degree of political selection and engagement among women, (ii) a strategic effort to stand out in a male-dominated field adapting a "challenger" rhetoric, or (iii) a genuine difference in the issues women find most relevant. To build on these findings, future research could utilize advanced text-embeddings or Structural Topic Modeling (STM) to better account for critical covariates like political affiliation or temporal shifts in discourse.

2 Literature Review

Gender differences in political communication have long been a subject of study across multiple scientific disciplines. Political scientists understand them as a strategic response of candidates to the gender stereotypes from the media and voters. In particular, perceived candidates' traits influence voters' interpretation of their ability to handle issues and candidates adapt their communication strategy to maximize their electoral support, including through the selection of topics covered in their political statements. Conventionally, women have been considered more credible to discuss and act on "compassion issues", such as education, health care, senior citizen issues, drug use or poverty, as they relate to notions of care and warmth. On the other hand, men have been perceived as more reliable on topics related to economy and security that are linked to traits such as strength and assertiveness [5].

Women in politics might have incentives to emphasize male-stereotypical topics as means to compete or gain credibility in a male-dominated field. At the same time, not adhering to feminine stereotypes might penalize them for not complying with normative expectations [5]. The underrepresentation of female candidates and the Cold War context are likely to play an important role too in the context of this study. Due to their marginal participation, women might have seen an advantage in adopting "challenger" rhetoric as opposed to an "incumbent" discourse [2] and voters' attention to military and economy-related issues are also likely to shape topic choice [3]. Overall, it is difficult to predict whether thematic differences will emerge in candidates' manifestos.

Kahn [3] finds that U.S. female and male senatorial candidates emphasize their respective stereotypical strengths. Men discuss economic and foreign affairs topics while women focus on social programmes and issues in their campaign appeals. However, recent research has found that this thematic gap is closing; and that the largest differences concentrate only among high-level politicians [5].

¹ All data and code used for the analysis can be found in my GitHub page.

3 Data

The analysis builds on candidates' manifestos from the legislative elections of the French fifth republic between the years 1973 and 1993. These belong to the Archelec corpus produced by Science Po.

3.1 Preprocessing and Filtering

The raw dataset combines the metadata —containing elections' contextual information and sociodemographic and affiliation information on candidates and substitutes —and the text files —the digitalized and transcribed manifesto documents. Initially, these consist of 21,167 records, the unit of observation being the individual election candidate.

The text preprocessing is conducted in three steps. First, the text is normalized : I keep exclusively alphabetic characters, including those with accents, and remove formatting issues (i.e., collapsing multiple spaces into a single one). Second, I implement word-tokenization : I apply lemmatization, remove general French stopwords, and keep exclusively nouns, adjectives and proper nouns using POS filtering. I subsequently obtain bigrams and remove custom stopwords manually identified for the electoral context of the corpus ². Finally, tokens that appear in less than five documents are removed to avoid the inclusion of irrelevant and rare terms.

Candidates with gender "non déterminé" are filtered out and I exclusively keep "homme" and "femme" as gender categories. The "non déterminé" entries amount to 836 observations across all years —less than 4% of the records —corresponding primarily to candidates from the 1993 election (76.31%) coming from "Nouveaux écologistes du rassemblement nature et animaux" (40.9%) and "Lutte ouvrière" parties (23.21%), the large majority (97.5%) without retrievable name nor gender. The EDA notebook provides an analysis of these observations.

3.2 Exploratory Data Analysis

The processed data contains 20,331 records. Only 10.62% of these correspond to female candidates, resulting in a heavily imbalanced corpus. Women representation does not evolve linearly over time : the largest shares are observed in the 1978 and 1993 elections, with 13.7% and 12.4%, respectively. These coincide with the years with the overall largest candidates' participation. On the other extreme, the lowest female representation occurred during the 1973 election, in which only 5.2% of candidates were women. Figure 1 shows the number of documents per year and gender, as well as the relative distribution of women candidates by year. I expect this imbalance to affect the LDA model by biasing it toward male-dominated discourse and by conflating gender-specific themes with temporal effects, thereby complicating interpretation.

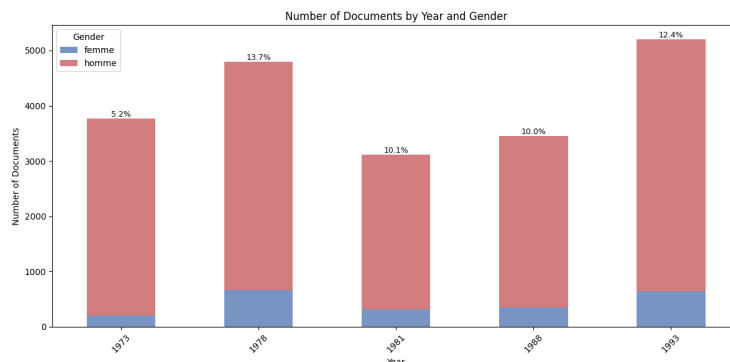


Figure 1: Document Distribution by Gender and Year

On average, the manifesto documents have 710.5 words, a slightly lower median (638), with half of documents comprising between 445 and 912 words. The number of final tokens in documents

²Custom stopwords are only removed after obtaining bigrams. This is done to keep context-specific terms that might be relevant together with another token. However, bigrams where both components belong to the custom stopwords list are removed.

is significantly lower given the text preprocessing. On average, documents count with 154.15 final tokens, a slightly lower median (142), and half of them have between 90 and 197 tokens. Figure 2 represents the distributions of text lengths and tokens counts by gender. Visually, no large differences seem to appear between men and women, despite a slightly more right-skewed distributions for men, overall suggesting that political manifestos provide a quite standardized support for candidates' political statements.

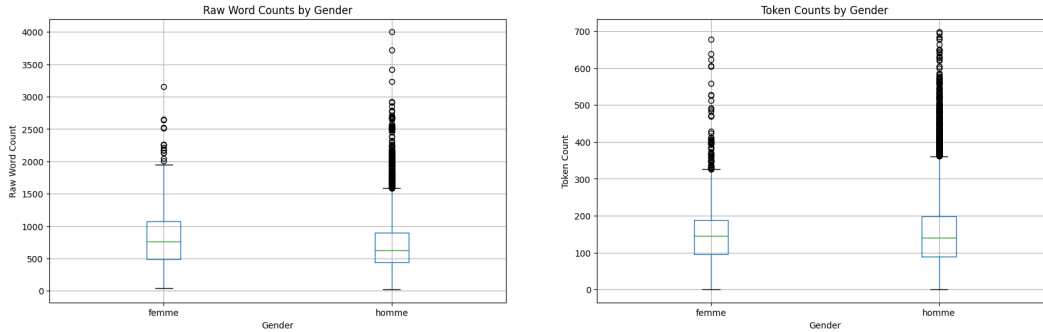


Figure 2: Raw Text Length and Token Count by Gender

3.3 Keyword Dominance and Gendered Vocabulary

Figure 3 presents the twenty top tokens by gender according to their relative prevalence in manifestos' lexicon³. Fourteen of these tokens are shared among men and women, potentially suggesting a common coverage of topics relating to socioeconomic issues, economic progress and development, as well as in reference to the Cold War context. This is captured in the use of terms like *travail*, *droit*, *socialiste*, *communiste*, *emploi*, or *société*.

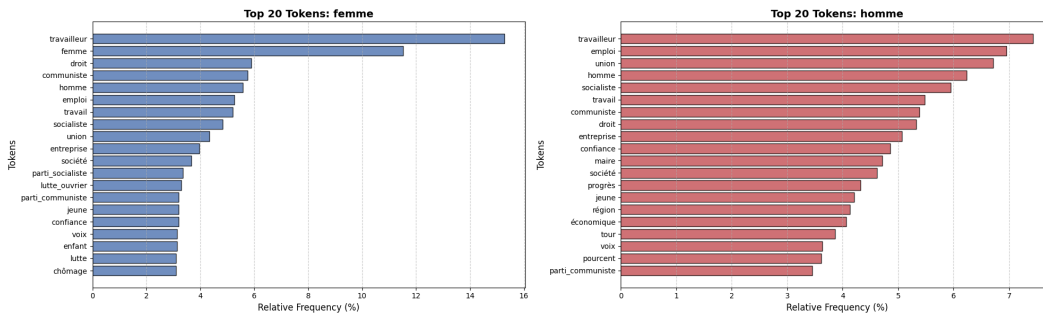


Figure 3: Relative Term Frequency by Gender

However, men and women do differ in some of their most frequently used words : men utilize general and institutional terms like *tour*, *économique*, *maire*, *pourcent*, *région* or *progrès*; while women resort to more ideologically-charged and left-wing oriented lexicon like *chômage*, *lutte*, *femme*, *lutte-ouvrier*, *parti-socialiste* and *enfant*. Figure 9 provides the word clouds representation of the most frequent terms by gender.

4 Methodology

4.1 Vectorization

I convert the tokenized text into a Bag-of-Words representation, resulting in a numerical representation of the corpus in which each document is represented as a vector of token counts. Tokens that appear in more than 80% of the documents are removed to exclude non-informative terms. The final document-term matrix contains 40,735 unique tokens.

³An analysis of top tokens by gender and year can be found in the EDA notebook.

4.2 Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA)

I employ Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), an unsupervised machine learning technique, to identify the latent thematic structure of the corpus. Developed by Blei et al. [1], LDA represents each document as a distribution over topics and each topic as a distribution over words. I train a LDA model on the processed Archelec corpus in the period of interest to ensure comparability of topics across genders and the stability of the estimated topics. A major limitation of not incorporating gender into the estimation process is that the model may understate female-specific thematic structures. I do not account neither for the temporal aspect of the data, which might give rise to similar issues.

Gender thematic differences are assessed examining the distributions of average topic proportions across male and female manifestos. To investigate whether variability in topics covered results from "intra-document" or "inter-document" heterogeneity, I compare the average topic entropy⁴ and average number of predominant topics –topics with more than 10% representation in a document –by gender to the distribution of documents by their "dominant" topic –most prevalent topic in a document –across genders. The first two give an idea of the level of "intra-document" heterogeneity in topics covered by gender while the last one proxies the thematic variability across documents for both men and women. These are used to further contextualize the topic modeling main findings.

4.3 Model Selection

The optimal number of topics for the LDA model is chosen to maximize average topic coherence based on the C_v score⁵. This metric is prioritized to possible others, such as Perplexity, as my primary goal is to obtain and characterize human-interpretable topics. Figure 4 plots the average C_v score and an inter-model topic similarity score based on average Jaccard overlap of topic word sets⁶ for models with 3 up to 20 topics. I keep the model with 10 topics as my preferred model⁷.

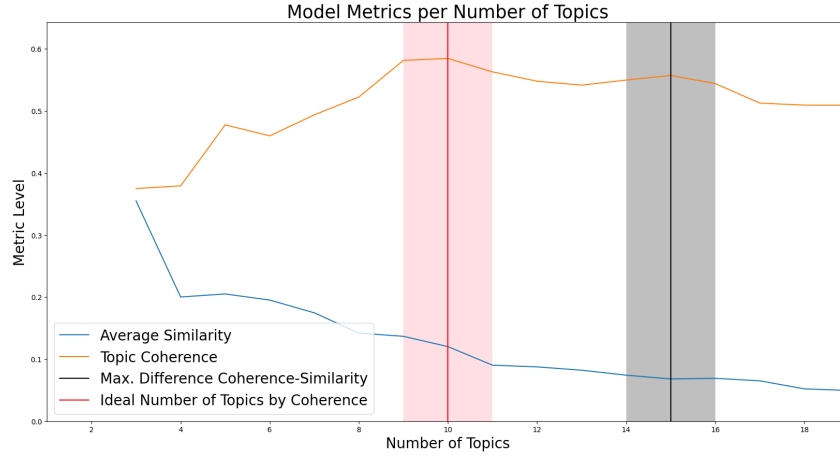


Figure 4: Average Topic Coherence (C_v score) and Similarity

⁴I use Shannon entropy according to the expression : $H_d = - \sum_{i=1}^K p_{d,i} \log_2 p_{d,i}$ where K is the number of topics, d is the individual documents and $p_{d,i}$ is the probability of each topic i in the document d .

⁵ $C_v = \frac{\sum_{k=1}^K \sum_{n=1}^N s_{\cos}(\vec{w}_{n,k}, \vec{w}_k^*)}{N \times K}$ where K is the number of topics, N is the number of top words per topic. The vectors $\vec{w}_{n,k}$ represent NPMI-based word representations derived from a sliding window co-occurrence matrix, and $\vec{w}_k^*$ denotes the aggregated topic representation constructed from its words in this space. $s_{\cos}$ measures cosine similarity between word-level and topic-level representations.

⁶This measure compares how similar the topics are when the model complexity changes. For each pair of consecutive LDA models, I obtain the Jaccard similarity between every topic in the first model and every topic in the second model, based on overlap in their top words according to the expression : $J(A, B) = \frac{|A \cap B|}{|A \cup B|}$. These pairwise similarities are averaged and indicate how much the two models' topic structures overlap. Lower values suggest that the topic structure shifts more substantially between models.

⁷I also assessed the model with 15 topics, which simultaneously maximizes the coherence score and minimizes the inter-model similarity score. Appendix D presents the main results from this analysis. However, manual inspection of the topic top words suggested that the 10 topic solution was more meaningful and relevant to study and interpret gender differences.

5 Results and Discussion

5.1 Thematic Structure of the Corpus

Table 2 presents an overview of the topics found, the associated top tokens, their token mass, coherence score, and a brief interpretation based on manual inspection of documents. Figure 11 shows the distribution of top tokens per topic.

5.1.1 Dominance of Broad Socioeconomic and Regional Development Issues

Results indicate that socioeconomic and national and regional development issues constitute the most frequently covered topic by candidates, encompassing around 47% of the token mass. Ecology and left-wing partisan and institutional rhetoric follow, covering 13.7% and 10.9% respectively. More marginal topics include Socialist / PSU Autogestion (7%), Elections and Local Mandates (6.4%), Regalian Traditionalist Rhetoric(4%), Gender & Labour Identity(3%), Alsatian & German(2.8%),Far-Left Class Struggle(2.5%) and Immigration and Insecurity (FN)(2.2%)⁸.

Overall, the model has a moderately high average coherence score of 0.59. Some topics are highly coherent, such as Alsatian & German (0.83) and Gender & Labour Identity (0.8), while others are more diffused, such as Socioeconomic & Regional Development (0.35) and Ecologist Entente & Green Politics (0.42), which are also the most prevalent in the corpus. This likely reflects the presence of generic political vocabulary that cuts across multiple topics and ideological stances (such as *emploi*, *travail*, *entreprise*, etc) and that hampers the model's ability to separate topics.

5.2 Gender-based Topic Analysis

This subsection identifies and interprets gender differences in political manifestos themes. Figure 5 provides the average topics distribution by gender and Figure 6 represents documents distributions by dominant topic and gender.

5.2.1 A Broader Thematic Landscape Among Female Candidates

Figure 5 suggests that there are several gender differences in the thematic structure of candidate manifestos. First, topics covered by men are, on average, more concentrated : more than half of the men's corpus mass (51.4%) focuses on Socioeconomic & Regional Development issues while less than 30% of women's does so. Around two-thirds of the remaining document mass among male candidates is distributed only across three topics (Ecologist Entente & Green Politics, Elections & Local Mandates and Left-Wing Partisan & Institutional Rhetoric). On the contrary, almost 80% of the remaining in women's case distributes evenly across six topics (we add to the three topics above, those on Socialist/PSU Autogestion, Regalian Traditionalist Rhetoricand Gender & Labour Identity).

This seems to be driven by larger thematic heterogeneity across women rather than women covering, on average, more topics than men within their individual manifestos. Indeed, measures of intra-document variability are nearly identical across genders : average topic entropy amounts to 0.687 for women and 0.703 for men ; and the average number of prominent topics discussed are 1.916 and 1.922, respectively. Conversely, Figure 6 shows that, on average, the distribution of the dominant topic varies more for women than for men.

5.2.2 Women's Topic Differentiation and Ownership

A second interesting result is that women are more likely to focus on "outsider" / "challenger" issues and to occupy the poles of the ideological spectrum. For instance, around 16% of women's document covers ecology and environment related topics (vs. 11% of men's) and around 7.5-8% focus on Regalian Traditionalist Rhetoric and Socialist/PSU Autogestion respectively (vs. only around 4-4.5% of men's). Conversely, men tend to touch more upon institutional topics, such as Elections & Local Mandates.

⁸The topic Alsatian & German contains vocabulary in German and this is likely why the model identifies it as a separate topic. After having manually verified some of these manifestos, I decided to keep them in the analysis as they encompassed both French and German content. This is nevertheless a limitation in the preprocessing step and further discussed in the limitations subsection.

Table 1: LDA Results

N°	Topic Name	% Tokens	Word Examples	Interpretation	C _v score
9	Economic & Regional Development	47	Homme, emploi, socialiste, entreprise, maire, jeune, région, économique, confiance, travail	Discussions about economic growth, employment, and regional governance, development and progres.	0.35
4	Ecologist Entente & Green Politics	13.7	Emploi, environnement, écologiste, écologie, société, développement, nature, chômage, travail, homme	Environmental concerns and green political discourse linked to employment and society.	0.42
6	Left-Wing Partisan & Institutional Rhetoric	10.9	Communiste, parti communiste, union, voix, parti socialiste, travailleur, pourcent, victoire, emploi, ressemblent	Party-centered left-wing political messaging and electoral discourse.	0.48
2	Socialist/PSU Autogestion	7	Travailleur, droit, lutte, travail, ouvrier, salaire, femme, société, autogestion, entreprise	Worker-centered socialist discourse focused on worker governance and labor rights.	0.51
5	Elections & Local Mandates	6.4	Tour, confiance, maire, voix, dimanche, jean, union, socialiste, progrès, tête	Electoral campaigns, local leadership, and municipal political competition.	0.63
3	Regalian Tradicionalist Rhetoric	4	Front national, emploi, famille, immigration chômage, voix, sécurité, enfant, travail, aide, défense	Law-and-order, national identity, and conservative populist rhetoric.	0.65
8	Gender & Labour Identity	3.6	Travailleur, femme, lutte ouvrier, socialiste, homme, ouvrier employé, communiste, parti socialiste, grand capital, petit commerçant	Intersection of gender and class in labor and political identity.	0.8
1	Alsatian & German	2.8	die, für, alsace, von, strasbourg, eine, werden, sind, politik, dass	Regional/linguistic discourse reflecting Alsace and German language usage.	0.83
10	Far-Left Class Struggle	2.5	Travailleur, lutte ouvrier, homme, progrès, ouvrier, tour, lutte, intérêt, ministre, état	Militant left discourse centered on class conflict.	0.46
7	Immigration and Insecurity (FN)	2.2	Front national, avenir front, confiance, droit, chômage immigration, charge, peine mort, mère famille, suppression taxe, raison	Far-right discourse focused on immigration, insecurity, and social anxiety.	0.74

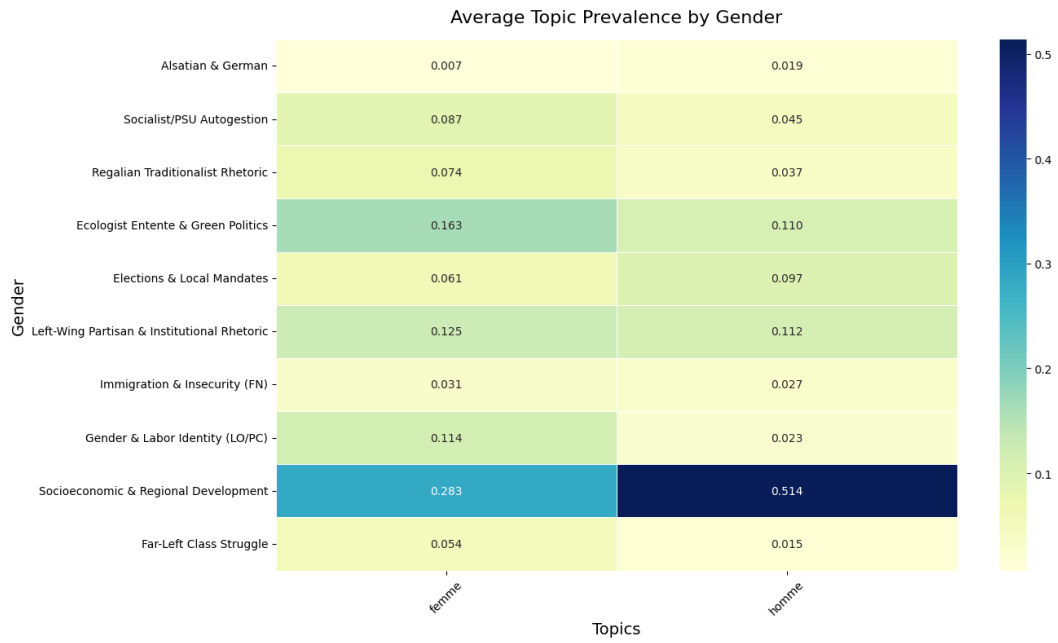


Figure 5: Topic-Document Average Distribution By Gender

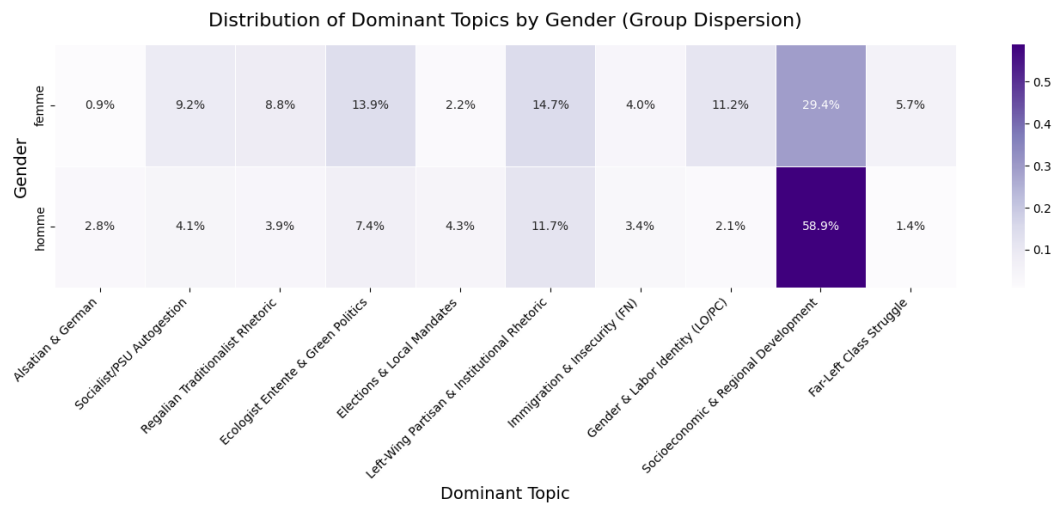


Figure 6: Inter-Manifesto Diversity.
Dominant topics are those that have maximal representation in a document.

Finally, the Gender & Labour Identity topic outstands for being primarily feminine, with 11.4% of women's document covering it (vs. only 2.3% of men's). That is, women discuss it at a rate five times higher than men. This points to a strategic positioning of female candidates in the intersection of gender identity and left-wing ideology, which does not seem surprising given the more frequent left-wing affiliations among the first female candidates. It indicates a clear difference in topic ownership and a differential topic structure according to gender which could become more evident in a balanced corpus.

Three mechanisms may account for the observed gendered differentiation in thematic emphasis. First, it is possible that women who enter politics are more selected than their male counterparts, and therefore present a higher degree of political engagement, preparation or issue-orientation. Second, female candidates may adopt distinct issue emphasis as a differentiation strategy within a male-dominated political environment to obtain visibility, credibility, or electoral appeal. Finally, the results may also reflect genuine differences in issue prioritisation based on lived experiences, social positioning, or constituency responsiveness thereby indicating differences in political preferences and perceptions of relevance.

5.3 Limitations

This study presents several limitations related to data processing and modeling choices. First, the inclusion of manifestos containing German vocabulary may introduce noise into the corpus, potentially hampering the ability of the model to estimate meaningful topics. Second, the LDA model does not account for gender imbalance in the corpus nor for temporal variation. As a result, the estimated topics may be disproportionately influenced by the majority group (men) or by periods with a higher number of manifestos, potentially leading to an over- or under-representation of certain topics. Finally, the analysis does not account for candidates' political affiliation. As party ideology is a key determinant of the topics emphasized in manifestos, this omission may confound the comparison by gender and limit the interpretation of observed thematic differences.

5.4 Comparison with NMF

To check the robustness of my results, I compare them to those obtained by a colleague using Non-Negative Matrix Factorization (NMF)⁹. Her approach identifies 15 optimal topics, which appear to capture sharper and more localized issues than the LDA model. For instance, it distinguishes between Ecologist Entente & Green Politics and Animal Rights & Ecology and brings new nuanced topics, including on youth, sovereignty, or state.

The model's larger discriminative capacity allows the appreciation of more subtle gender patterns, but overall confirms the main message from the LDA analysis. Topic choice by candidates is not gender neutral (see Figure 7). The thematic landscape of female candidates is richer and primarily centered around gender identity and left-wing issues. Importantly and in line with LDA findings, women use the Gender & Labour Identity at a rate five times higher than their male counterparts. These results also confirm that men are more prone to focus on general topics, such as economic and regional development, and institutional matters.

6 Conclusion

The results of this study demonstrate a clear gendered structuring of political communication in France between 1973 and 1993, where male and female candidates presented distinct thematic priorities. While men largely focused on "high politics" and structural concerns—specifically socioeconomic development and institutional frameworks—women exhibited a significantly greater thematic breadth by engaging with "outsider" or "challenger" issues and positioned themselves more frequently in the extremes of the ideological spectrum. Ultimately, these findings suggest that women either engaged in strategic adaptation of their agendas to gain electoral support or had different trajectories and concerns than their male counterparts, which translated into different issue coverage, or both.

Interestingly, the greater thematic diversity observed in the female corpus is driven by inter-document heterogeneity rather than individual candidates covering a wider array of topics within a single mani-

⁹The NMF analysis referenced in this section was conducted by Cynthia Francis as part of the course's final project.

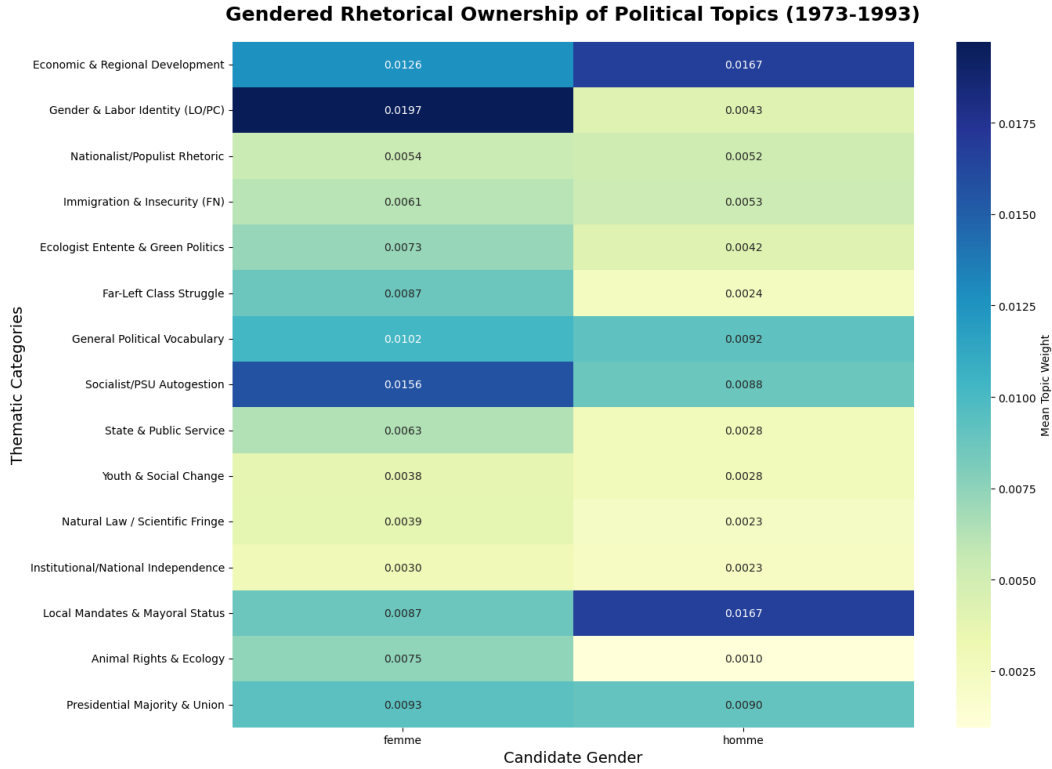


Figure 7: Comparative NMF Heatmap.

festo. This indicates that while political manifestos provided a standardized format for all candidates, women in politics during the Cold War and post-Cold War transition were more heterogeneous in their political identities and policy interests than men. These results emphasize the importance of considering gender as a key factor in policy agenda-setting and highlight how marginalized groups can drive thematic innovation in political discourse.

Future research could explore the use of more advanced embedding-based models, such as BERTopic, to identify semantically richer and more coherent topic structures. In addition, implementing structural topic modeling as developed by Roberts et al. [4] would be particularly valuable, to allow for the inclusion of document-level covariates—such as year and party affiliation—directly in the estimation of topic prevalence. This would enable a more rigorous assessment of gender differences by accounting for temporal dynamics and ideological composition.

References

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A Appendix : Raw Token Distributions

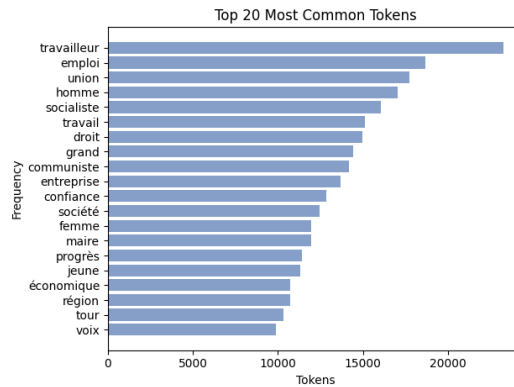


Figure 8: Raw Token Distribution

B Appendix : Word Clouds

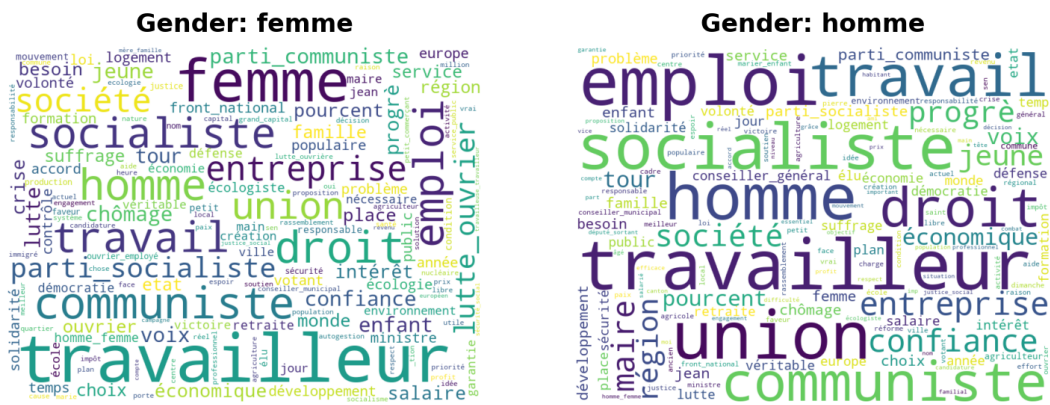


Figure 9: Word Clouds : Token Distribution by Gender

C Appendix : Top Words Distribution - 10 Topic Model

LDA Topics

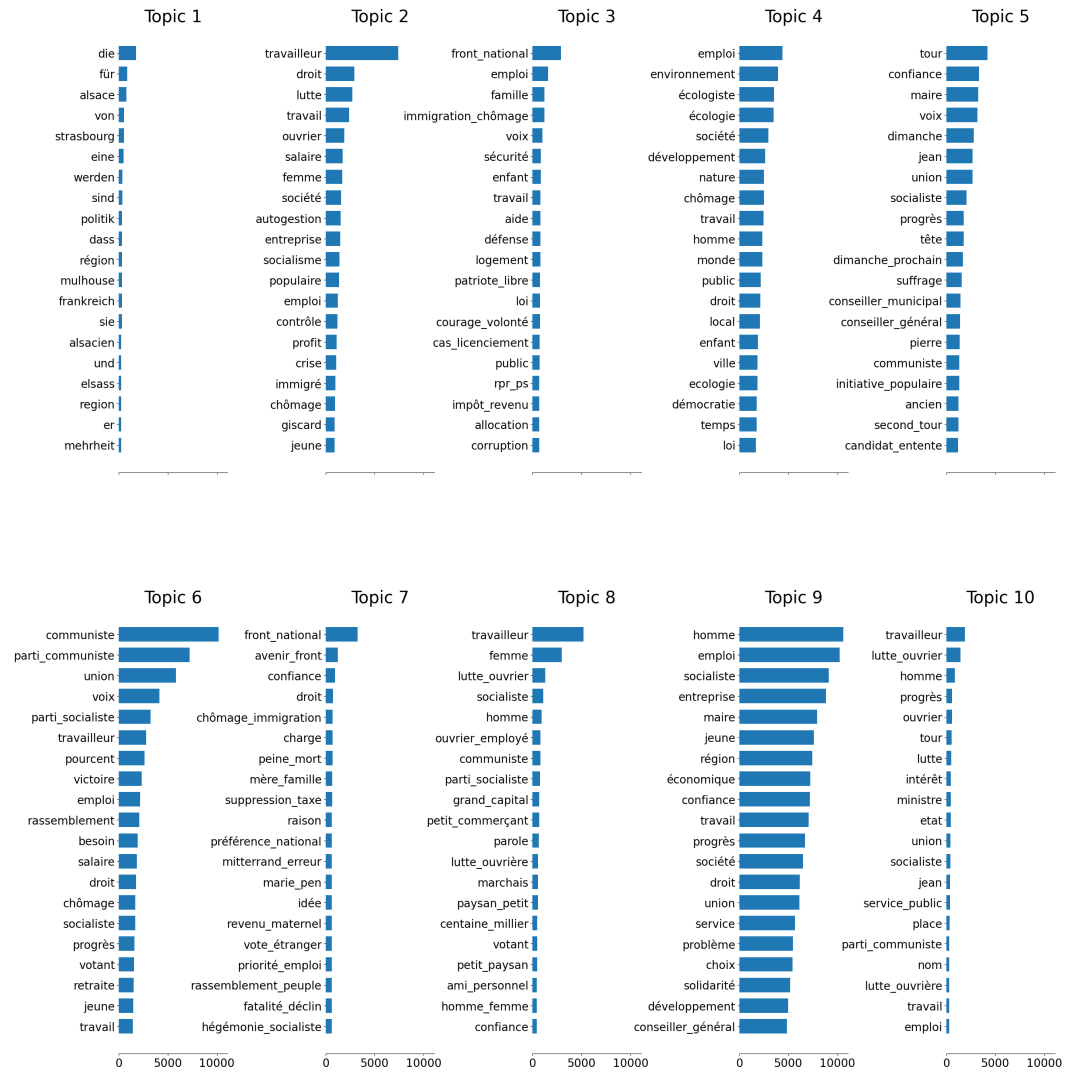


Figure 10: Top Words Absolute Distribution by Topic

D Appendix : 15 Topic Model Figures

Table 2: LDA Results: 15 Topic Model

N°	Topic Name	% Tokens	Word Examples	C _v score
9	Economic & Regional Development	53.0	Emploi, homme, entreprise, région, socialiste, économique, société, travail, jeune, progrès	0.34
6	General Politics Vocabulary	12.7	Communiste, union, parti communiste, voix, parti socialiste, socialiste, victoire, tour, pourcent, ressemblément	0.56
14	Socioeconomic and Labour Rights	6.9	Travailleur, droit, travail, salaire, lutte, emploi, ouvrier, chômage, femme, socialisme	0.46
12	Local Mandates & Mayoral Status	4.5	Maire, jean, confiance, tour, conseiller général, dimanche, conseiller municipal, conseiller régional, pierre, vice	0.59
1	Ecologist Entente & Green Politics	4.1	Écologiste, écologie, ecologie, société, environnement, nature, nucléaire, droit, temps, monde	0.57
11	Gender & Labor Identity (LO/PC)	3.1	Travailleur, femme, lutte ouvrier, socialiste, ouvrier employé, communiste, homme, parti socialiste, petit commerçant	0.79
15	Socialist/PSU Autogestion	2.8	Travailleur, lutte, lutte ouvrier, psu ouvrier, tour, union, progrès, populaire, bourgeoisie	0.43
7	Alsatian Regionalism & Border Identity	2.7	Die, für, Alsace, responsable actif, von, strasbourg, eine, courage volonté, werden, sind	0.66
8	Immigration and Insecurity (FN)	2.1	Emploi, voix, famille, enfant, impot revenu, patriote libre, aide, politicien, responsable coupable, temps	0.82
10	Nationalist/Populist Rhetoric	1.9	Front national, avenir front, immigration chômage, marie pen, peine mort, confiance, mère famille, droit, préférence national	0.71
3	Regalian Traditionalist Rhetoric	1.7	Femme, travailleur, carte séjour, immigré, droit, famille, défense, entreprise, travail, homme	0.37
5	Right Wing Nationalist Reform	1.5	Initiative populaire, candidat entente, appel, priorité emploi, chômage immigration, fidèle conviction, liberté enseignement, socia, raison avenir, liste	0.43
4	Law, Governance & Institutional Trust	1.2	Loi, corse, professionnel création, avenir ment, nature, état, confiance, accord, libéral, résultat	0.29
13	Parliamentary Discourse & Institutional Figures	1.0	Homme, intérêt, travailleur, place, état, travail, nom, suffrage, parti communiste, formation	0.51
2	Identity & Institutional Politics	0.9	Union nouvelle, vote étranger, délit crime, conviction vote, homme, europe, dimanche join, nature animal, européen, ardenne	0.28

LDA Topics

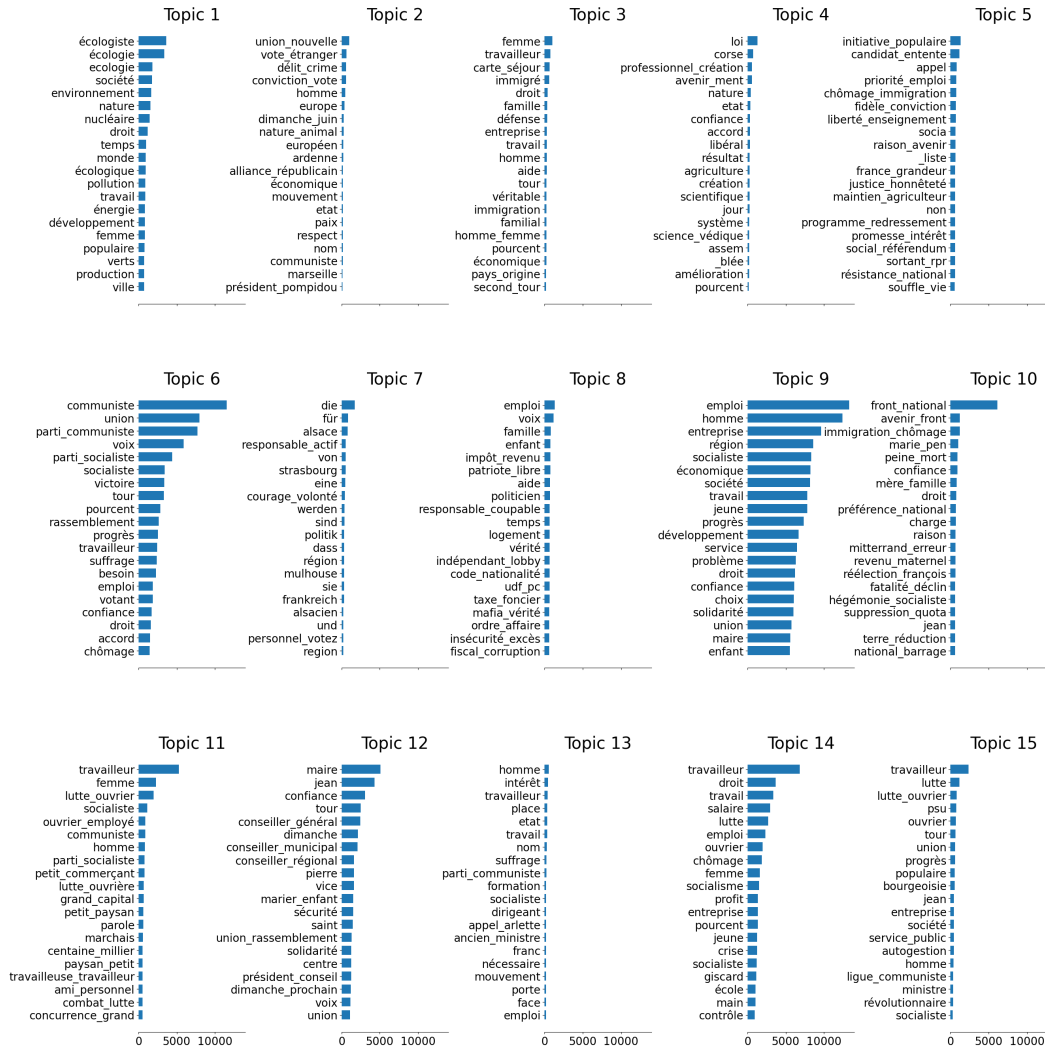


Figure 11: Top Words Absolute Distribution by Topic